

Blink

Climbing the ladder of civilization

2–4 players · age 10+
60–90 minutes · competitive
Toby Siko · Deep Diversions
deep-diversions.com/blink

A game of tricks and territory, in which the cards you play are also the budget you spend. Win the trick and you act first — but every card in that winning meld still has to become a settler, a new tile, an attack, or a coin.

THE ROUND

Everyone plays a meld at the same time — **any cards whose ranks form an unbroken run**. Duplicates are free and suits are irrelevant, so one rule replaces straights, sets and full houses. The highest total wins the trick and acts first; matching the winner's card count and losing costs you a card; the meld that ranks last takes a coin.

Then, in that order, every player spends the very cards they just played. Each one settles a unit, explores a new tile, attacks a neighbour, or is cashed for gold — always on terrain matching the card's suit, always next to ground you already hold. You never choose a move separately from the cards: **the meld is the budget**.



✓ one card is always a run



✓ one rank, doubled



✓ 2 then 3



✓ 2, 3, 4 all present — doubles are free

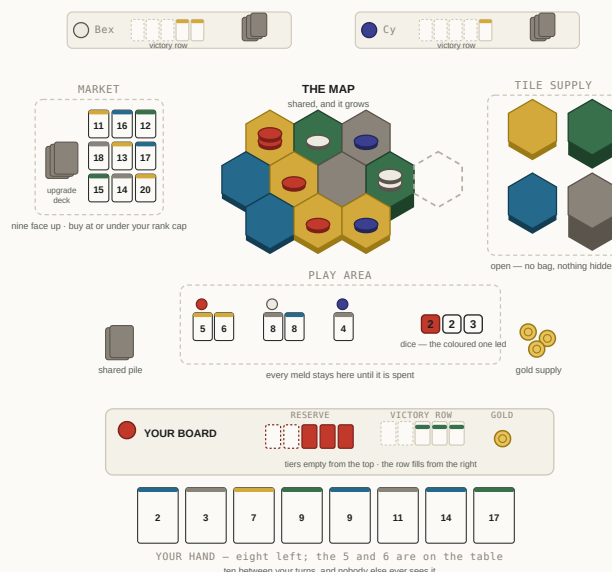


✗ nothing at rank 3 — the run is broken

The whole meld rule in five rows. Only the last is illegal, and only because nothing sits at rank 3.

GROWTH IS THE CLOCK, AND THE BILL

Your twenty units sit in five tiers on your board and leave from the top. Each tier you empty raises your meld size, your free movement and the rank you may buy from the market — and raises the food your people cost every time your hand recycles. Expansion pays for itself only while you keep taking ground, and placing your last unit ends the game.



The table from your seat. The map is shared and grows all game; every meld played stays in the play area until it is spent.

COMBAT IS A DUEL

An attack is the card you spent. The defender answers with a card from hand plus the terrain's defence — forest one, mountain two — and the higher rank wins. Clear the last defender and the ground changes hands on the spot. It is the only moment in the game when you act on somebody else's turn, and it is what makes the cards you hold back worth holding.

HOW IT ENDS

The game ends when a player places their last unit, or the market of advanced cards thins to its last layer. Finish the round, play one more, then score: one point per unit on the map; one per card in your victory row, plus the rank showing in its centre slot; and three for each terrain type where you hold the largest connected stretch.

WHY IT PLAYS DIFFERENTLY

Trick-taking asks one question — can I win this? Blink asks it twice, in opposite directions. The meld that takes the trick is the meld you must now spend, and a card cashed for gold is a settler you chose not to place. The map remembers every answer.